3 | Competing Arguments About South Asian Proliferation

Nuclear weapons proliferation in South Asia has been a major international concern because of the region's violent history and because of India and Pakistan's refusal to accede to the international nonproliferation regime. The debate over South Asian proliferation shifted after 1998 from the question of whether India and Pakistan would acquire nuclear weapons to the question of what effects their nuclearization was likely to have on regional security. Two camps have dominated this post-test debate. The optimist camp argues that given nuclear weapons' ability to make any war between India and Pakistan catastrophically costly, nuclear proliferation should lower the likelihood of regional conflict. The pessimist camp argues that political, technological, and especially organizational pathologies will make proliferation dangerous, potentially leading to deterrence failure and war despite nuclear weapons' deterrent effects.

In this chapter, we offer our own views of nuclear weapons proliferation. Ganguly argues that nuclear weapons, contrary to much existing scholarship, can actually stabilize conflict-ridden relationships. Most nuclear pessimists underscore the dangers of organizational pathologies, and highlight the long history of Indo-Pakistani tensions and the existence of ongoing territorial disputes to argue that the introduction of nuclear weapons into the region would inevitably enhance the possibilities of conflict. These considerations, while seemingly compelling, are neither especially relevant to the South Asian context nor likely to render the region more war prone. Instead, careful examination shows that in the South Asian case, nuclear weapons have actually had quite a different effect. They